



TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's
Programming Languages

A data-driven analysis for technology decision-makers

21.25%

Python #1 Rating

+2.02%

C Surges to #2

48.97%

Top 4 Concentration



Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

The top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) collectively account for 48.97% of the total TIOBE index.

Rank	Prev	Language	Rating	Rating %	YoY Change
1	1	Python		21.25%	-2.59% 
2	4	C		11.55%	+2.02% 
3	2	C++		8.18%	-2.90% 
4	3	Java		7.99%	-2.37% 
5	5	C#		6.36%	+1.49% 
6	6	JavaScript		3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic		2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL		2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R		1.88%	+0.94% 
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal		1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl		1.75%	+1.05% 
12	12	Scratch		1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran		1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust		1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB		1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go		1.29%	-1.49% 
17	17	Assembly language		1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP		1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada		1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift		1.04%	+0.44% 

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Legacy languages show surprising resilience while Go suffers its sharpest decline -- the largest absolute drop of any top-20 language.

📈 RISERS

Perl

Jumped from 24th to 11th

Entrenched in infrastructure and text processing

YoY Change
+1.05%

+13 ranks

R

Climbed from 16th to 9th

Data analysis and scientific computing stronghold

YoY Change
+0.94%

+7 ranks

Swift

Re-entered top 20, from 26th to 20th

Apple platform growth drives adoption

YoY Change
+0.44%

+6 ranks

C

Surged from 4th to 2nd -- largest rating gain

YoY Change
+2.02%

📉 FALLERS

Go

Dropped from 7th to 16th -- sharpest decline

Possible displacement by Rust in systems space

YoY Change
-1.49%

-9 ranks

C++

Slipped from 2nd to 3rd

Largest percentage-point drop among top 5 after Python **-1 rank**

YoY Change
-2.90%

Java

Fell from 3rd to 4th

Continuing steady multi-year decline from 25%+ peak

YoY Change
-2.37%

-1 rank

Python

Holds #1 but posted largest YoY rating drop in top 5

YoY Change
-2.59%

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

C is the only language that has remained in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Key Patterns Across Decades



Python's Ascent

Unranked before 1991, entered top 30 by 2001, took 25 years to reach #1. Peaked above 25% before settling at 21.25%.



C's Resilience

Top 2 across all nine measurement points. The only language with this distinction over four decades.



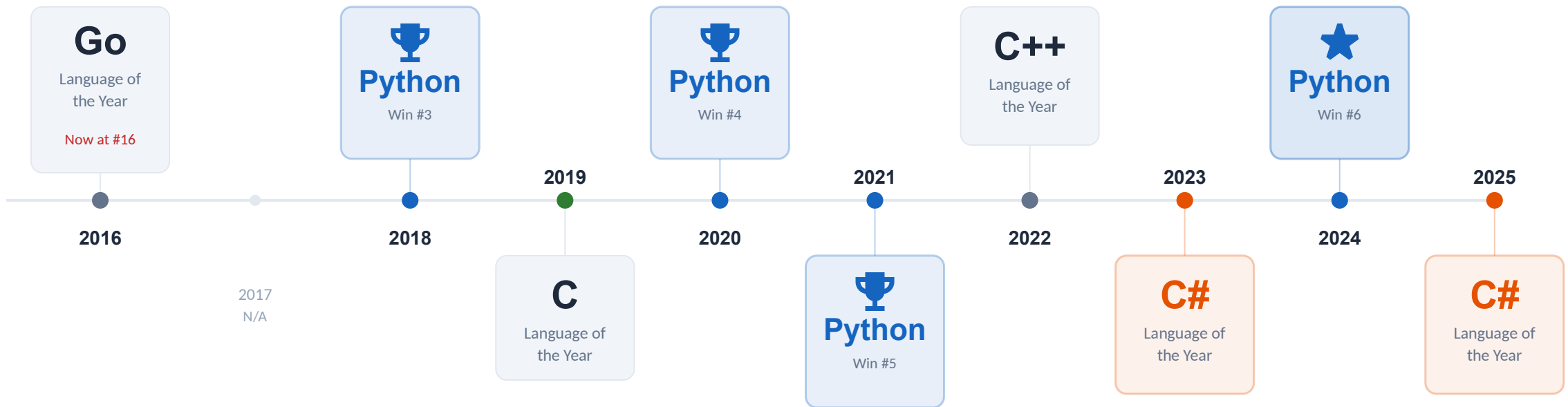
Java's Decline

Dominated 2005-2018 at #1, steadily fallen from 25%+ to under 8%. Now 4th and still declining.

■ Current #1 ■ Top 2 all decades (C) ■ Peak position Gray = rank below 10 or unranked

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

The award goes to the language with the largest rating gain each year. Python has won 6 times (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024). Note: 2017 winner not available in source data.



6

Python wins (all-time record)

2

C# wins (2023, 2025)

1

Go win (2016) -- now at #16

1

C++ win (2022)

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Actionable implications for hiring, training, and tooling investments based on March 2026 TIOBE data.



Python: Dominant but Declining

21.25% rating -- more than double the #2 language.
However, -2.59pp YoY is the largest drop among the top 5.



Action: Continue Python investment, but monitor the trajectory.

Watch if C and other languages continue closing the gap.
Diversify critical infrastructure beyond a single language.



Systems Space: C Surges, Go Falls

C gained +2.02pp (4th to 2nd). Go lost -1.49pp (7th to 16th).
Rust holds steady at 14th (+0.09pp) -- possible Go displacement.



Action: Re-evaluate Go-centric strategies; watch Rust adoption.

Go's sharpest-ever decline contrasts with its 2016 peak.
C's resurgence reflects embedded and systems-level demand.



Legacy Language Revival

Perl: 24th to 11th (+1.05pp). R: 16th to 9th (+0.94pp).
Fortran holds top 15. These serve entrenched communities in
scientific computing, data analysis, and infrastructure.



Action: Don't abandon legacy language expertise prematurely.

Niche communities can drive surprising resurgence.
Maintain skill pipelines for Perl/R/Fortran where applicable.



Concentration Risk: Top 4 = 48.97%

Python (21.25%) + C (11.55%) + C++ (8.18%) + Java (7.99%)
account for nearly half the entire index, despite 50+
tracked languages. High concentration = high dependency risk.



Action: Diversify language investments across your portfolio.

Align hiring with multi-language strategy: core + emerging.
Track Swift (re-entered top 20) and Rust (steady climb).